Task – 5

Part A) Case Study: UPI/Online Payment Fraud

Type of Cybercrime

UPI (Unified Payments Interface) Fraud / Online Payment Fraud

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What is UPI Fraud?

UPI fraud occurs when cybercriminals trick victims into authorizing fraudulent payments or gaining access to their bank accounts through deception. With India's rapid adoption of digital payments, UPI fraud has become one of the most common cybercrimes targeting college students and young adults.

How It Happens – Step by Step

Step 1: Victim receives a phone call from someone posing as a bank executive, customer support agent, or delivery service.

Step 2: The fraudster claims there is an urgent issue — such as a blocked account, failed KYC update, or undelivered package requiring refund.

Step 3: Victim is asked to download a screen-sharing app (like AnyDesk or TeamViewer) or share OTP received on their phone.

Step 4: Victim is tricked into entering UPI PIN under the pretense of "activating" a feature or receiving a refund.

Step 5: Money is instantly transferred from victim's account to the fraudster's account.

Step 6: Fraudster disappears, and the victim realizes the money is gone with no way to reverse the transaction.

Who is Targeted?

- College students who frequently use UPI apps (Google Pay, PhonePe, Paytm)
- Individuals who are new to digital payments
- People in urgent situations who may not verify the caller's identity

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Consequences

Financial Loss: Victims lose hard-earned money — often ranging from ₹5,000 to ₹1,00,000 or more

Emotional Distress: Anxiety, shame, and stress after being tricked

Time Wasted: Hours spent filing complaints and visiting banks

Account Compromise: In severe cases, further unauthorized transactions occur

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Real Incident Reference

According to the National Crime Records Bureau (NCRB), India reported over 1.16 lakh cyber fraud cases in 2023, with UPI fraud constituting a significant portion. College students are among the most vulnerable groups due to their frequent use of digital payment apps and limited awareness of evolving scam techniques.

Source: NCRB Annual Report 2023